

Guggenheim Museum

A Modernist triumph built to house an unrivaled collection of modern art

Solomon Robert Guggenheim (1861–1949) was born into wealth and increased his fortune with his gold mines and other investments. He began collecting art in the 1890s, and after World War I retired to devote



◁ SPIRALING DOWN

Inside the museum, the continuous spiral gallery gently flows around the central atrium, which is lit from above by a central skylight.

△ THE HONEY DIPPER

The museum has been nicknamed the “honey dipper,” as it resembles the utensil used to scoop out honey from a jar.

himself full time to his collection. In 1939, his artistic foundation, set up to foster the appreciation of modern art, established a museum to house his growing collection. As the art overflowed its rented home, Guggenheim wrote in 1943 to Frank Lloyd Wright (1867–1959), America’s preeminent modern architect, asking him to design a permanent home for his paintings.

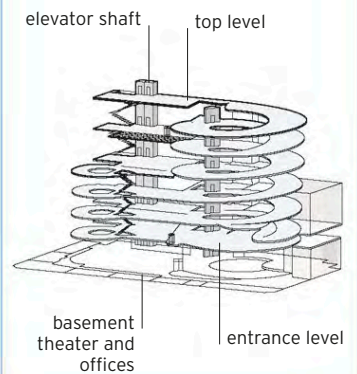
A spiral of art

Wright responded with one of New York’s most extraordinary buildings. Cylindrical in shape and wider at the top than the bottom, it features a unique ramp gallery that runs in a continuous spiral around the outer walls, reaching up to the ceiling skylight. The finished museum is an inverted circular ziggurat that took 7 years to build before it opened to the public in 1959. Inside and out, the building overwhelms.



THE SPIRAL RAMP

Wright designed the museum as an inverted ziggurat (an ancient tiered pyramid or mound), its spiral design similar to a nautilus shell. His plan was for visitors to take the elevator to the top, then slowly walk down the ramp, viewing the artworks before admiring the spectacular atrium at the bottom.



Guggenheim **never** saw his museum; he **died 10 years before** it opened

Space Needle

Seattle’s saucer in the sky, built as a centerpiece of the 1962 World’s Fair

Seattle’s landmark Space Needle, with its distinctive hourglass shape and elevated viewing platform, has been a symbol of the city since 1962. Standing 604 ft (184 m) tall, it commands views of downtown Seattle and its inlet, as well as the more distant Cascade Range and Olympic Mountains.

Strong and sturdy

Construction of the tower began on April 17, 1961, and was completed on December 8 the same year. Built to withstand earthquakes of up to magnitude 9.0 and winds of up to 199 mph (320 kph), as well as lightning strikes, the tower now features the world’s first and only revolving glass floor, known as the Loupe. Recent modifications to remove the mullions that restrict the view from the observation deck have brought the tower closer to the design intended by the original architects.

▷ INTO SPACE

The top of the Space Needle contains the rotating glass floor of the Loupe and an open-air observation deck above it.

